Fiche de correction

Passing the Flame. Othello, or the trap of theatrical illusion.

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Model answers, grids and indicated standards for the ten lessons, the midpoint commentary and the summative tasks.

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Short model answers and grids, in English, for the C1 sequence. These are bearings, not scripts to dictate.

Lesson 1. Diagnostic

A good first record names visible facts (two figures, a Venetian interior, a closeness that is not quite ease) and then a limit: the painting cannot prove a plot, a character, or a moral.

The video is not summarised as a life-story. A useful note inherits a method: read between the lines; do not confuse a convincing image with a fact.

Grid, informal /10. Observation (4); a stated limit of the image (3); language (3).

Lesson 2. The contract of « I am not what I am »

A strong 200-word record will:

- divide the speech (honest knaves / shows of service / the profession of the second sort);
- collect the vocabulary of the mask;
- treat the last line as a pact with the spectator, not only as a confession.

Weak scripts stop at « Iago is a liar. »

A compact model. Iago first dismisses the « knee-crooking knave », then praises those who keep « visages of duty » while their hearts attend on themselves. He professes himself of that second kind: « In following him, I follow but myself. » The last five lines raise the mask into a law. If outward action ever showed the heart, he would be exposed to daws. « I am not what I am » therefore flatters the audience: we think we have been taken into a confidence. That flattery is already the trap of the play.

Lesson 3. The Senate

Look for three strands in the tale (service, wonders, Desdemona’s listening), a real use of the chiasmus, and a precise account of Brabantio’s prolepsis against Othello’s pledge.

A compact model. The speech wins a hearing because it is public evidence, not a private outburst. Wonders and service sit together, and Desdemona’s « greedy ear » is part of the proof. The chiasmus (« She lov’d me for the dangers I had pass’d, / And I lov’d her that she did pity them ») makes two loves look like one cause. « This only is the witchcraft I have us’d » turns storytelling into a legal answer. Brabantio plants a future (« She has deceiv’d her father, and may thee »). « My life upon her faith », spoken next to « Honest Iago », hands the trap a tool: absolute trust, declared in public.

Lesson 4. Ocular proof

The key is the shift: from « I'll know thy thoughts » to a proof that must « bear no hinge nor loop to hang a doubt on ».

The green-eyed monster should be treated as a metaphor that *does* something: it feeds on what it looks at, and it mocks the meat. Jealousy is not only a feeling here; it is a way of seeing that consumes its object.

In the optional soliloquy, *haply* reasons are tried and then dropped. « I'll not believe't » does not close the desire for proof; it sits beside it.

Lesson 5. III.4, and the midpoint

Written record (three trusts). A strong script will keep all three: Othello's trust in Desdemona; Desdemona's trust that truth and a clear conscience will be legible; Emilia's trust that silence can serve two loyalties.

Bearings for the six tasks.

1. Emilia's line is short, flat, and a lie. The audience already holds the theft.
2. Humoral words (*moist*, *hot*, *liberal*) are moralised (*devil*, *castigation*, *heraldry*). A body is made to mean more than the person intended.
3. Desdemona returns the hand to the wedding. Othello does not follow her there; he climbs into sententia.
4. The Egyptian tale may be lore, intimidation, or a mix; the verse will not settle it alone. What it *does* is install a law in a gift.
5. « What and if it were? » is grammatically innocent and, in this hermeneutic, fatal: the hypothetical is heard as a confession.
6. Emilia names a self-begotten monster and still does not speak. Knowledge without speech is another form of the trap.

Midpoint commentary, a short shape (not a dictated essay).

- *Thesis, example:* III.4 applies the method of III.3 to a hand, a gift and a conversation, under the eyes of an audience that already knows the theft.
- *Part 1.* Dramatic irony and the moist hand: an over-reading of the body; heraldry against a wedding truth.
- *Part 2.* The curse-narrative: the gift becomes a warrant; « magic in the web » is a meaning sewn into cloth.
- *Part 3.* « What and if it were? » and Emilia's silence: a grammar of good faith, and a knowledge that does not speak.
- *Close.* The trap of perception is not the handkerchief. It is a way of reading that no longer admits a person.

Lesson 6. Othello as spectator

A good table keeps three positions. Cassio speaks of Bianca; Iago has already captioned the scene; Othello supplies Desdemona as the referent.

Bianca's « take out the work » is a useful contrast with III.4: the same object can be a sacred warrant or a pattern to copy.

A compact model opening. Shakespeare makes Othello a spectator of a scene whose meaning has been prepared for him. « Now he begins the story » shows a man who thinks he is reading a caption. Each gesture is then made to confirm it. We watch a watching, and that formal fact is the point of the lesson.

Lesson 7. Two meanings

The score should be accurate, not crowded. One Cassio line, fully worked, is better than a vague retelling of the whole exchange.

Accept a clear use of *referent* and *assigned story*. Reject a paragraph that only says « Othello is mistaken ».

Lesson 8. Light, and « Speak of me as I am »

Bed soliloquy. Strong scripts notice that tenderness does not stop the deed: it is folded into the justification. « Put out the light, and then put out the light » turns a word from lamp to life, with the knowledge that the second light cannot be restored.

Last speech. « Speak of me as I am » is a demand for a true record, and it opens a series of shaped portraits. « Not easily jealous, but being wrought » is almost true, and almost an extenuation. Both readings can stand, if they are argued from the list of portraits and from the stroke at Aleppo.

Lesson 9. Answering the critics, and Hugo

Rymer. He has seen a disproportion (cloth / murder). He has refused to see that the cloth is not the cause, but the object onto which a method has been forced.

Johnson. The balance of fire and cool malignity is just as a first tempo. *Credulous* must be tested against « My life upon her faith »: trust used as a tool, not a weak mind.

Coleridge. « Motive-hunting of a motiveless malignity » names a habit of reasons that do not finally account for the harm. It can also be resisted: the hunt for motives is itself a performance, in keeping with I.1.

Hugo. Mark the treatment of the inversion and of the idiom. A good 150-word paragraph is about the theatrical contract of the line, not about « which language is prettier ».

Lesson 10. Summative commentary, a full model in short moves

This is a bearing, not the only right script.

Thesis. Shakespeare makes Othello a spectator of his own deception by teaching him, in advance, what a scene will mean, and by giving him objects and gestures that seem to confirm the lesson. The trap is a way of reading, prepared in I.1, fed in III.3 and III.4, and shown as theatre in IV.1.

I.1 and I.3. The spectator is first flattered into a pact of knowing. Othello, by contrast, wins a hearing with a tale, then stakes his life upon a faith, in the hearing of « Honest Iago ». Trust and theatre are already in place.

III.3 and III.4. A wish to know becomes a wish to be confirmed. A hand, a gift and a hypothetical are made into proofs. The audience holds the theft and must watch a meaning being sewn into cloth.

IV.1. The formal centre: a man watches a conversation whose caption has already been written. Cassio's referent is Bianca; Othello's assigned story is Desdemona. « That should be my handkerchief » recognises the object and misreads the story.

V.2, if used. The same rhetoric can dress a killing as « the cause », and a death as a record (« Speak of me as I am »). Lucidity and self-fashioning arrive together.

Close. The guiding question does not ask for a slogan about rumour. It asks whether we, who have been Iago's first audience, can explain the trap without enjoying the pact too much. A C1 last paragraph can open onto the tip of the spiral (who becomes the victim when images outrun persons) and then stop, honestly, at what a commentary cannot settle.



Flashcards, brief keys

- *I am not what I am*: a contract with the spectator, not only a confession.
- *My life upon her faith*: absolute trust, spoken in public, usable later.
- *Ocular proof*: a demand that doubt have no remaining hinge.
- *Magic in the web*: a meaning installed in an object.
- *What and if it were?*: innocent grammar, fatal in this hermeneutic.
- *Begot upon itself*: jealousy that does not need its pretended cause.
- *Now he begins the story*: a spectator who thinks he is hearing a caption.
- *Put out the light, and then put out the light*: a word turned from lamp to life.
- *Speak of me as I am*: a demand for truth, and a last self-portrait.